

Visa Payment Decline & Remediation Guide

1. Overview

This guide describes common card payment decline reasons, their meaning, and the permitted remediation actions for merchants and acquirers. For each reason code, "retry" means re-submitting the same authorization, and "reversal" means voiding a previously approved-but-uncaptured authorization.

2. Decline Reason: `insufficient_funds` (Reason Code 51)

Meaning: The cardholder's account does not have sufficient funds to cover the transaction at the time of authorization. This is a soft decline and is often temporary.

Retry: Allowed. The merchant may reattempt the authorization. Under Visa reattempt rules, a declined transaction may be retried up to a maximum of 15 attempts within a 30-day period, but no more than 4 attempts are recommended for `insufficient_funds`, ideally spaced at least 24 hours apart to allow the account to be funded.

Reversal: Not applicable, because the transaction was declined, not approved.

Recommended action: Wait and retry later; notify the cardholder if it continues to fail.

3. Decline Reason: `do_not_honor` (Reason Code 05)

Meaning: A generic decline from the issuer. The issuer will not approve the transaction but gives no specific reason. This is a hard decline.

Retry: Discouraged. Immediate automated retries are unlikely to succeed and may be flagged as abuse. The cardholder should contact their issuing bank before any retry. At most 1 retry is permitted, and only after cardholder action.

Reversal: Not applicable for a declined transaction.

Recommended action: Ask the cardholder to use a different card or contact their bank.

4. Decline Reason: `expired_card` (Reason Code 54)

Meaning: The card has expired or the expiry date provided is incorrect.

Retry: Not allowed with the same card details. Retrying will continue to fail until the cardholder provides an updated card or expiry date.

Reversal: Not applicable.

Recommended action: Request updated card details from the cardholder. Maximum retries with the same details: 0.

5. Stuck or Pending Authorizations

Meaning: A payment that remains in PENDING status well beyond the expected settlement window (for example, more than 30 minutes) is considered stuck. This usually indicates an authorization that was approved or initiated but never captured or settled.

Retry: A new authorization should not be created while the original is still outstanding, to avoid double charging the cardholder.

Reversal: Allowed and recommended. A stuck, uncaptured authorization should be reversed (voided) to release the hold on the cardholder's funds. Reversal must be performed by operations and is not automatic.

Recommended action: Reverse the outstanding authorization, then create a fresh authorization if the purchase is still required.

6. General Retry Limits

Across all reason codes, never exceed 15 authorization attempts for the same transaction within 30 days. Any action that moves money — retry, reversal, refund, or capture — requires human approval and must not be executed automatically.